

CHAPTER 19

The Ladder: How Money Becomes Optional

“No society can legitimately call itself civilized if a sick person is denied medical aid because of lack of means.”

Aneurin Bevan, *In Place of Fear* (1952)

In this chapter:

- The rules that make survival cost money were written by people, and people can rewrite them. Here are nine steps. The first seven have precedents, with dates and receipts; the last two hold the plan together.
 - Start where the food already is: count what’s thrown away, feed whoever asks, then make the meal a public service like the library.
 - Money stays. It just stops being the ticket to staying alive.
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The county chambers smelled like wet coats and floor wax. Rain had followed them down the valley, and the co-op came in shaking it off: Curtis in his route jacket, Reuben with an accordion folder under one arm, the kitchen coordinator with a banker’s box of receipts, Devendra with a child asleep against his shoulder and the other one counting ceiling tiles. Irene Calder came last and took the aisle seat as if she’d been assigned it.

Elijah had fourteen slides. He’d built them over three nights: cost per delivered meal, failure modes with names beside them, a curve of what the route could carry if the county matched what the co-op had already set aside for repairs. He’d timed the talk at eleven minutes.

The clerk read the rules off a laminated card. Public comment, three minutes per speaker. A red light would come on at thirty seconds.